EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

What Happens to the Soul When We Die?

Given Monday 24 March 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6:6-7

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 6 (The Soul), Chapters 6 and 7

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 24 March 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: The Soul So Far

The penultimate shiur before the Pesach break. Next week, at the summer time of 6 to 7, comes Chapter 8, on *gilgul*, which closes the essay; Essay 7 begins after Pesach.

A point not yet made: Jew and non-Jew

Before the recap, the Rabbi pointed out something he thought worth noting. **Nowhere in this essay does Saadia differentiate between the soul of a Jew and the soul of a non-Jew.** He touches on the subject briefly in a later essay, but for all intents and purposes, everything learned here about the *neshamah* applies to all human beings. "And the same is in the Rambam's philosophy as well. The neshamah of a Jew and a non-Jew are not intrinsically different." Others, especially in the kabbalistic literature, make the idea of an essential difference very pronounced. "But in Saadia, he makes no difference of this, and we assume this applies to all human beings."

Chapters 1 to 5

- **Chapters 1 to 3:** Saadia disproved various theories of the soul and gave his own. It is "a very subtle discipline." The soul is **created**, **simultaneously with the body**, an ethereal essence with the power of speech, finer and purer even than the spheres, and called by several names.
- **Chapter 4:** Why would God put this elevated essence into a lowly body? Because God does nothing wrong, and this is the soul's nature: it only functions together with the body. "You can't ask me that God should create a neshamah which functions out of the body, because that's no longer a neshamah... That's an angelic sphere." Only with the body can it attain the eternal bliss of Olam HaBa. The soul's pain is either the result of its own choices or a kind of compensation for the future.
- **Chapter 5:** Body and soul are **one entity**. Whenever the Torah speaks of reward, punishment or consequence, it means both together, not the body alone, the soul alone, or (as some held) the bones alone.

This is the view of the vast majority of the Chachamim: Olam HaBa is for body and soul together. The **Rambam**, as the class learned in **Hilchot Teshuvah**, famously held that Olam HaBa is for the soul alone. The Rabbi has said in other shiurim that the difference between these views may not be so great, "they actually could be saying the same thing in different words," but he left that for the essay on *techiyat hametim*.

Tonight: **Chapter 6**, on how long body and soul stay together, and **Chapter 7**, on what happens to the soul at death. "Two relatively straightforward chapters. Chapter 7 is quite interesting."

Chapter 6: The Length of a Life

"There's one point to this chapter; it's a short chapter."

A set lifespan, with additions and deductions

The Torah speaks of a person having a set number of days. So Saadia posits that every human being is created with a **certain lifespan**, whether 50, 60, 70, 80 or 90 years. Throughout life a person can **increase** that lifespan through positive action or **decrease** it through negative action. During that time, body and soul are united as one.

Saadia's verses for the basic lifespan:

- One of the blessings in **Parashat Mishpatim**: **את מספר ימיך אמלא**, "I will fill the number of your days," allowing you to live the full length set out for you.
- To Moshe: **הן קרבו ימיך למות**, your days are drawing to an end.

Then he adds that Hashem at times **adds or subtracts** (the Rabbi noted a word missing from the printed text, **מוסיף** or **פוחת**).

Foreknowledge and choice, again

God knows how long you will live, including all the additions and deductions, but this "does not take away our choice." This is exactly Saadia's answer in Essay 4. There he was the first to raise the question of how God's foreknowledge can be reconciled with our free will, and he answered that God knows but does not cause. "He knows what's going to be the end of our entire lifespan based on the choices we will make in our lifetime, but He's not causing that."

How the Rabbi understands it

There is a basic vitality, a basic span of time, that every body is given. Some are born with a weak constitution and a natural span of 60, others with a strong one and a span of 90. The default "at least in those days" was 70. Hashem may then add, say, another 30 years so that a person lives to 100, or take 30 away so that he lives to 40. "Each person with their basic lifespan, with increases or decreases, and that's how it works."

Proofs for additions and deductions

- **Mishlei**: **יראת ה' תוסיף ימים**, the fear of Hashem adds days.
- **Chizkiyahu** prayed, and Hashem said, I will add fifteen years to your life. "So there was a basic lifespan of Chizkiyahu, and then God adds him 15 years."

- The many rewards in the Torah of "I will lengthen your days": you have a set number, and they will be lengthened.
- **The plague.** When the people complained, a plague broke out and many died, and it was halted with the incense. If everyone simply died at his set time, "then a plague would make no sense," and stopping it would have achieved nothing. The plague must have been a deduction from people's natural lifespans.
- **Shmuel I 26**: David says of Shaul, **כי אם ה' יגפנו או יומו יבוא ומת**, either Hashem will strike him, or his day will come and he will die. The verse itself distinguishes between a person's natural day and a punishment that befalls him.

The disclaimer

Saadia ends with a warning: don't misquote me as saying that every righteous person lives long and every wicked person lives short. That is up to how God plays it out. If a righteous person did not live long, his reward must be in the world to come; if a wicked person lived long, his consequence must come in the next world. "There is a time for everything."

The Rabbi added that the **Ibn Ezra** says exactly the same: "your days" in the Torah are the set days every human is created with, according to his nature, constitution and vitality, which Hashem then increases or decreases. In answer to a question he mentioned the midrash about **King David and Adam**, which illustrates that a lifespan can be shaped by factors beyond a person's natural constitution.

Don't make the calculations

Q: Someone does a great deal of good and dies suddenly, not old. How are we meant to think about it? Perhaps without the good he would have died earlier, or with more good he would have lived longer?

The Rabbi said Saadia essentially asks this himself. After everything he has said about long and short lives, don't start calculating: he lived these years because he did that, she lived those years because she did this. Yeshayahu says in the name of Hashem, **כי לא מחשבותי מחשבותיכם**, My thoughts are not your thoughts.

"I've mentioned this point many times in the past... it's impossible to judge anyone in this world, in terms of what their reward will be or punishment will be in the next one." We can judge according to the laws Hashem gave us for this world: the Torah tells a court what to do with a murderer or with someone who eats forbidden food. But a person's full identity for the next world depends not just on his choices but on **the struggle he had to make them**. Two people can do exactly the same act, and in God's eyes one has far greater weight than the other, because for one it was easy and for the other it was hard.

"This is the most basic answer to **צדיק ורע לו רשע וטוב לו**... How do you define what a tzaddik or a rasha is? ... You never know and I don't know, no one will know. And anyone who says that they do know, doesn't know." So we can accept the chapter as theory, but in practice we should never start applying it to individual lives.

Asked how we even know there is a world to come, he said there are many proofs, which will come in Essays 7 and 9; Saadia is "the first one who goes through this systematically."

Chapter 7: What Happens at Death

The essay so far: what the soul is not (Chapters 1 and 2), what it is (3), why God joins it to a body (4), body and soul as one entity in the world to come (5), and the lifespan (6). Now: how does the soul leave the body when we die, and what happens to it? When the soul departs, we can no longer speak, move or communicate; that is the sign that it has left.

"Here he relies completely on tradition. He's got no philosophical or rational proofs for this." And, the Rabbi noted, "Saadia takes a statement in the Gemara very literally, which is interesting."

Point 1: The angel and the fear

What do the Chachamim tell us? When a person's lifespan has come to an end, **an angel is sent** to separate body and soul. It appears to the dying person as:

1. a figure holding an **outstretched sword**, pointed at him;
2. of a **yellowish substance, like fire**;
3. **full of eyes**;
4. and those eyes are **bluish**. (The Hebrew translation is not quite right here; in the Arabic the colour is blue.)

The angel does not attack. But the sight is so terrifying that the person dies of fear. Saadia is quoting the Chachamim; the Gemara in **Avodah Zarah** says something very close to this.

Saadia's verses. Where do the Chachamim know this from? Saadia finds it in Scripture:

- **The sword:** in Divrei HaYamim, David lifted his eyes and saw the angel with its sword drawn, and after he prayed the sword was returned to its sheath.
- **Fire:** Yechezkel describes the angels as **כגחלי אש בוערות**, like burning coals of fire.
- **Eyes:** Yechezkel also says they were full of eyes all around.
- **Blue eyes:** this one is from reason. If the eyes were the same yellowish fiery colour as the body, there would be no clear demarcation between them. You only see eyes when they contrast, and blue stands out against yellow and orange.

He adds two more proofs that one can die of fear:

- **At Har Sinai**, the people came to Moshe and said, **למה נמות כי תאכלנו האש הגדולה הזאת**, why should we die from this great fire? The Midrash says they actually died and were revived; the simple reading is that they almost died of fright. "So the more so when he's got a sword about to pierce you."
- **King David** saw the angel. It did not come to attack him, but he was terrified of it, and as a result he lived with a constant coldness for the rest of his life.

Why was King David always cold?

"Very interesting," said the Rabbi, "because the traditional way... I always learned" was different. The verse says that in his old age David was covered with garments and could not get warm. The well-known explanation: when David cut the corner of Shaul's garment, he disrespected clothing, and so clothing "disrespected him" and never warmed him. Saadia's reason is different, and the Rabbi went looking for the source and found it: a Midrash, brought also by

the **Radak**, that David was startled by the angel's appearance and suffered from that chronic coldness until the day he died.

The Radak brings both explanations, along with the simple one: David was only 70, but worn out by all his wars, and as a person ages his natural moisture lessens and he feels cold. "I don't know why one understanding is more known than the other."

Literal or metaphorical?

"Saadia takes this literally, which others don't." Some commentators explain that "full of eyes" means you cannot hide from this angel: wherever you creep, it sees you. The fire, too, could be read metaphorically. "No, Saadia takes it literally. He believes and he understands that a person dies because of fear and of this image, and every time a human dies, they see this thing just before they die." The Rabbi said he himself would have read it more as a metaphor. "I suppose we'll find out one day on our deathbeds."

Q: Doesn't the Gemara say some souls leave like a hair drawn out of milk? Yes: for some people death is as gentle as drawing a hair from milk, and for the wicked it is like pulling thorns out of wool. The Rabbi reconciled this with Saadia: everyone dies of fear, but the shock needed varies. For the righteous, whose body and soul are in harmony, "just a little disalignment is enough to separate them." For the wicked, who lived with body and soul out of harmony, "you need a full electric shock in order to separate you."

Near-death experiences. One participant mentioned the tunnel and the light. "No one's ever been there and come back, so anyone can say lots of things. I only believe what the Chachamim tell us." Perhaps that is the beginning of Olam HaBa; "I've got no idea." Another found the angel frightening and hard to believe, since an angel is meant to be beautiful. The Rabbi answered that there are destructive angels too, not only cherubs. The Chachamim say it is true "in some kind of sense, whether literally or metaphorically."

And the Shechinah at the bedside? The Gemara, brought by **Rashi in Parashat Vayechi**, says the Shechinah is at the head of a sick person's bed, which is why Yaakov bowed toward the head of the bed. Perhaps the Shechinah is this angel. In the Rabbi's understanding, and that of the Ramchal and the Rambam, an angel is not a creature with a name; it is an emanation from God. So at a deathbed there is a greater manifestation of godliness, "for the good or for the bad." What is the Shechinah? "A relatively more tangible manifestation of godliness in a certain place," as at the Kotel.

"I just find it remarkable that, essentially, Saadia is positing, the Gemara is positing, every person dies out of fear... Even if you died from illness, you died from fear at the end of the day."

Point 2: Why can't we see the soul leave?

Because, as Chapter 3 taught, the soul is so fine and transparent, like the heavenly spheres, which cannot be seen because of their refinement. The Rabbi's analogy: take ten glass candle holders, put each one inside the other, and put a candle inside. Because of the light and the transparency of the glass, it looks like one thing; you cannot see the ten glasses. So too the soul leaves, but it is too fine to be seen.

Point 3: The waiting room

What happens to the soul once it leaves the body? It is **kept guarded until the end of days**, when body and soul reunite. This will be developed at length in Essay 7.

For Saadia, Olam HaBa is a world that will be **created in the future**, to be enjoyed by body and soul together. Everyone has a portion unless cut off, and each will be resurrected, reconnected, and enjoy it eternally according to his own level. "But what happens until then?" Someone who died today, or 2,000 years ago, must wait. (A participant called it "the waiting room in Gan Eden," and the Rabbi agreed: "Very good.")

- **Your condition in the waiting room matches your level in the world to come.** A great portion of Olam HaBa means a higher level in the waiting room; a small portion, a lower one.
- The souls of the righteous are with God; "the people who aren't so lucky are hovering around… not such a pleasant experience."
- **This is where the concepts of Gan Eden and Gehinnom come from.** They are kinds of waiting rooms, where soul is separate from body. The real bliss or the real consequence is Olam HaBa; "this is not the real thing, it's a taste of what's going to be." So even a very righteous person who dies today is not fully enjoying Olam HaBa until he is reconnected with his body.

The soul and the decomposing body

Saadia adds a point that "slightly explains the concept of Kaddish, twelve months." The hardest time for the soul is right after death. All souls suffer something **until the body decomposes**, because the soul sees what is happening to the body. "Remember it's one entity." The body is being consumed by worms and maggots.

Saadia's analogy: just as a person would be upset seeing the house he lived in for many years burned down or overrun with thorns and thistles, "I lived here, I have memories here," so the soul is upset seeing the body consumed.

How much pain depends on the person's level. Saadia says the worms are to a dead body like a needle to a living person. The Rabbi expanded: some people squirm and panic at the very thought of an injection; others say "boom, put it in my vein, all is good." Same with the grave.

The source is the verse in Iyov, **ונפשו עליו תאבל**, his soul mourns over him. "This is what we mean when we talk about **חיבוט הקבר**," the suffering of the grave. Some understand it as a literal beating; Saadia understands the pain as the soul watching the body decompose. Everyone has some moments of it, which is how one can explain the benefit of **Kaddish** in the first months, when the body is at the height of decomposition.

A participant found all this very frightening. "Well, it's reality. Whether you like it or not, we are eaten up by maggots and worms." Asked whether the soul waits for one year, he answered: no, until the world to come is created, which could be hundreds of years; the first stage of distress lasts until the body decomposes.

Point 4: How long the wait lasts

The separation lasts **until Hashem has created all the human beings He intends to create**. Then He will bring the soul from heaven and the body from the ground and reunite them, and

techiyat hametim will begin. **והרוח תשוב אל האלקים**: the spirit returns to Hashem, and then returns to be reunited. "The entire entity of the human will come together."

What Olam HaBa will be like will come in Essay 9. The map ahead: Essay 7 is *techiyat hametim*, Essay 8 is *ge'ulah*, Essay 9 is Olam HaBa and reward and punishment.

Summary

Chapter 6

1. Every person is created with a **set lifespan** based on his constitution, which Hashem may **lengthen or shorten** according to his conduct (Chizkiyahu's fifteen years, the plague, "either Hashem strikes him or his day comes").

2. God's knowledge of the final total does not take away our free will, as in Essay 4.

3. **Don't calculate.** Long life does not prove righteousness, nor short life wickedness. "My thoughts are not your thoughts." No one can judge another's standing for the next world, because it depends on the struggle behind each choice.

Chapter 7

1. **We die of fear** at the sight of a fiery, yellow angel full of blue eyes with a drawn sword. Saadia takes the Chachamim literally and finds each detail in Scripture. Hence too, he says, King David's lifelong cold.

2. **We cannot see the soul leave** because it is too fine, like ten nested glasses around a flame.

3. **The soul waits** in Gan Eden or Gehinnom, a waiting room matched to its future level, and suffers while it watches the body decompose: Saadia's reading of *chibbut hakever*, and a reason for Kaddish.

4. **The wait ends** when Hashem has created all the souls He intends; then body and soul are reunited for the resurrection.

Coming Up

Next week, at 6 to 7, the last shiur before Pesach: **Chapter 8, *gilgul***. "That will be a really fascinating shiur, I'm telling you that. We're going to survey all the different views with regards to gilgul."

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